

Synthetism

In 1886 and 1888, Gauguin stayed at Pont-Aven and Le Pouldu in Brittany, where he mixed with younger artists including Émile Bernard (1868–1941), Louis Anquetin (1861–1932), Jacob Meyer de Haan (1852–95), Charles Laval (1862–94) and Paul Sérusier (1863–1927). Dissatisfied with the Impressionist obsession with light and objective representations of nature, Gauguin began using colour to create expressive effects.

Bernard and Anquetin were developing a style that became known as Cloisonnism after medieval Cloisonné enamelling. It inspired Gauguin, who in 1888 painted *The Vision After the Sermon: Jacob Wrestling with the Angel*. With areas of vivid colour outlined in black, the painting was also inspired by Japanese woodcuts, colour theories and Symbolism. Gauguin called his new approach Synthetism, referring to the flat colours and distorted shapes synthesizing with the artist's intention or the mood of the subject. By infusing notions as memory, imagination and emotion, he believed that Synthetism was more meaningful than Impressionism.



Gauguin, *The Vision after the Sermon*, 1888